Choosing which AI ideas deserve to be built

IS5542 · Design Thinking guest lecture · 10 October 2026

The part of the lecture I keep returning to is the value–complexity matrix. From an AI and machine learning perspective, I can assess whether a model might perform a task. The matrix asks a further question: is solving that task worth this organization's resources? It gives me a more useful way to judge an AI proposal than the sophistication of its technology. A technically impressive idea can still be a poor priority.

Jobs To Be Done and "How Might We" statements provide the starting point for that judgement. A problem needs a specific user and an intended outcome before anyone can assess its value. In the workshop, the lecturer recommended considering high-value, low-complexity problems first, then selecting a small number for further work. His advice to let the manager vote last during dot voting was particularly practical. It recognizes how easily a discussion about priorities can become a discussion about what the boss prefers. Still, voting shows a team's preferences; it does not establish that customers need the selected idea.

The music-identification example made this limitation concrete. A student shared an AI-generated proposal for identifying songs through rhythm or humming. The AI described it as high value and low complexity because relevant recognition techniques were mature. The lecturer then pointed to similar functions already available in phones and apps. I would be cautious about accepting the AI's classification. Existing alternatives may reduce the additional value of a new product, while mature algorithms do not guarantee that a particular organization has suitable data, access to a music catalogue or the ability to build a reliable service. A convincing explanation can hide assumptions on both axes.

I also found the lecturer's exceptions to the usual order useful. He described starting with lower-value, easier projects to develop AI literacy, while some organizations pursue difficult projects for their strategic value. This means the matrix cannot produce a universal ranking. A small pilot may be worthwhile because people learn from it, even when its immediate financial return is limited. Conversely, repeatedly choosing easy projects could consume resources without addressing the organization's most costly problems. I would want a clear account of what each project contributes and over what period before treating its quadrant as a decision.

For a future GenAI project, I would use the matrix to decide what to investigate next. For example, a customer-support assistant might appear easy to build and promise savings. I would first examine a sample of support requests and compare a limited prototype with the current process, measuring resolution quality and the work still required from human agents. Errors that create extra contacts could erase the expected savings. Those observations could move the proposal to a different quadrant or justify narrowing its scope. The lecture has made me more attentive to the evidence behind a priority: I would now ask what could change the ranking before committing to it.